even considered it for India's national bird but rejected it due to its name. Today, the bustard has disappeared or been decimated in six states and many of its grassland habitats are irrevocably lost.

Each account is enriched by sharply observed profiles of notable figures—from Sálim Ali's infamous short temper and Humayun Abdulali's dubious driving skills to Rahmani's complex equation with his mentor, BNHS director J.C. Daniel. The most revealing account is one dedicated to Ali Hussain, the bird trapper from rural Bihar whose exceptional prowess earned him a trip to America.

Despite its wealth of material, *Living with Birds* often reads like a report or diary, at times bogged down by numerous acknowledgements. Its language is simple and direct. Some information, such as bird taxonomy, does not reflect recent revisions. Unlike Sálim Ali's memoirs, which captured the popular imagination, *Living with Birds* talks solely to committed bird enthusiasts, when it could have done so much more. ■

–Bijoy Venugopal

Lost and Found

A new anthology of essays on the quest to find birds that haven't been spotted for decades

In 2021, a couple of years before the terrible ethnic conflict started in Manipur, the state threw up some of the most reliable sites to see one of India's stunning but rare pheasants. Named evocatively as 'Nong-in' in the Meitei language, it means 'one who follows the tracks of the rain'. Also known as Mrs. Hume's pheasant to the English-speaking world, it is named after the wife of the temperamental but prodigious ornithologist Allan Octavian Hume.

With the help of the Maharaja of Manipur, Hume described the pheasant in 1880 and dedicated the discovery to his missus. In the intervening 140 years, it had been reliably seen only a couple of times, once notably by the late ornithologist Ravi Sankaran in the mid-2000s. So, when Harmenn Huidrom, one of Manipur's competent birdwatchers who had been involved in a few discoveries of uncommon birds in the region before, verified claims advertised by the village chairman of Razai Khullen of about 350 Nong-ins in their area, it sent jubilant shockwaves through the Indian birding community.

Most of the essays are **FIRST-PERSON ACCOUNTS** by committed birders

This episode and 11 others are part of *The Search for India's Rarest Birds*, a new anthology of essays by birdwatchers and researchers on their quest to find birds that haven't been seen for several decades. The book is published by Juggernaut and Indian Pitta Books. The latter is an imprint run by Anita Mani, who is one of the editors of the book. The other editor is the noted birder Shashank Dalvi.

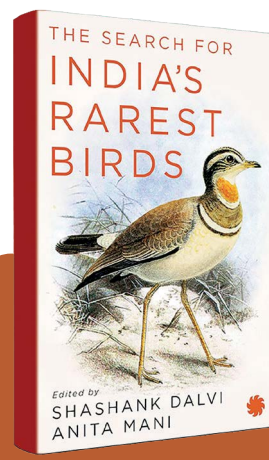
Mani and Dalvi also co-write the essay on Nong-in. Being visible at night, when the pheasant roosts—and not in the daytime—is what makes the Nong-in rare. The pheasant is also rare due to the uncommonness of its preferred conifer-oak forest habitat. Rarity is the central epithet around which each essay is written. The reader is taken on an adventurous ride through incredibly diverse habitats across India, including the Andaman & Nicobar Islands.

The essay on the Jerdon's courser, a nocturnal ground-dwelling bird, tells us how it was rediscovered in 1986 in the dry deciduous savannas of Cuddapah district in Andhra Pradesh after decades of no-show. It has gone incognito again since 2008, waiting to be rediscovered once more. Its presumed low numbers makes the courser rare.

Occurrence of a bird only in very few places and altitudinal elevation can also make a bird rare. The essay on Banasura Chilappan, a species of laughing thrushes, tells us that it is found only on a few peaks in Wayanad district in Kerala.

Almost all the essays are first-hand accounts. Not only does the zeal of the writers come through but their emotional journeys keep the reader hooked. One slight quibble is that people like Huidrom, who had found a bird, could have been given an opportunity to write an essay too. The book is a fantastic account that tells us that it takes a conscious endeavour to see rare birds. It is also a reminder that the might of the human hand can push these birds to being lost forever. ■

–Vrushal Pendharkar



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